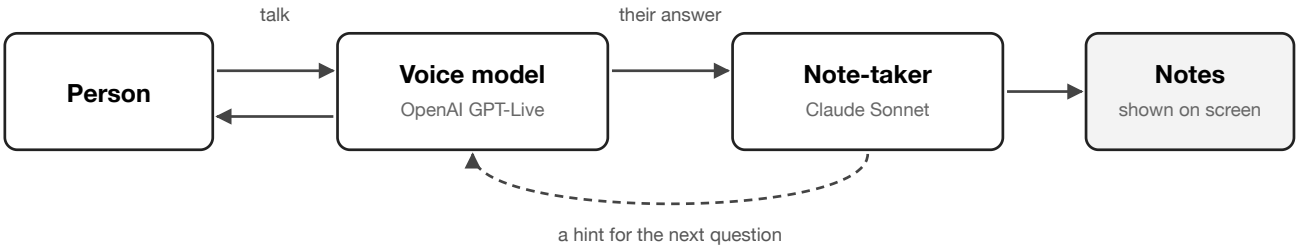
How the Viven interviewer works, and why

Utkarsh Kanwat · November 2026 · viven-interviewer.utkarshkanwat.com

The goal is simple to say: talk with someone for twenty minutes, by voice, and come away with notes good enough for a digital twin to answer the way they would. It should work for anyone, not just people who are good at explaining themselves. Five things shaped the design. Each one started as a mistake.



The voice model does the talking. The note-taker listens, writes the notes, and suggests where to go next.

1 The voice model talks, the note-taker listens

At first the note-taker wrote every question and the voice model read it out. Replies took two to eight seconds, and sometimes the voice model said its own line and then the scripted one, so two questions came out at once. Now the voice model answers on its own, in about a second, because it can hear when someone has finished. The note-taker reads each answer, updates the notes, and sends a quiet hint for the next question. It doesn't always take the hint, and that's fine: a late question is worse than a different one.

2 No behaviour rules in code

I added code to stop repeated questions, cap how long it stays on one topic, and trim long questions. Each rule broke a normal conversation somewhere. It cut questions off mid-sentence, blocked a fair follow-up, and left a topic the person was enjoying. I removed them. The prompt now describes what a good interviewer does, and the model decides. Code only moves data and saves it.

3 Notes in the person's own words

The first version saved labelled facts: a value, a rule, a story. The labels didn't help anyone, and a lot of what got saved was about the call ("didn't like being interrupted") rather than the person. Now it keeps a small folder of short notes, such as work, family and views, written in their words. After each call it rereads everything against the transcript and tidies it up.

4 Ask about what makes them different

In my own test call it asked five questions about how I prioritise my work. Every answer was saved, but anyone would have said the same. A twin learns nothing from that. Now it starts with what the person is known for, since that's what people will ask their twin. Then it gets a rough picture of the rest of their life, and only digs in where an answer is unusual. After each answer it privately asks itself whether the topic is covered or what's still missing, and moves on when it's covered.

5 A screen that doesn't feel like a test

The first screen looked like a debugging tool, and that makes people perform. Now you type your name and start talking. The notes appear next to the conversation as they're written, so you can see what it understood. There is one button to end, and when you come back it picks up where you left off.

How I check changes

I don't trust a prompt change until it's tested. Ten simulated people, each with hidden facts about their life, are interviewed by the real system. Afterwards a separate model answers questions about each person using only the notes, and a model from another company grades the answers. The latest round covered more of each person's life (2.8 areas instead of 2.0) without losing any facts. Most big rewrites I tried made things worse. Small, precise wording changes were what helped.

Built with TypeScript on Cloudflare Workers. Voice: OpenAI GPT-Live. Notes: Claude Sonnet through OpenRouter. The full experiment log is in THINKING.md.